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United States Patent	12396443
Kind Code	B2
Date of Patent	August 26, 2025
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Ornament assembly

Abstract

A system of decorating a housing that includes a base and a plurality of decorative elements. The decorative elements are irremovably disposed on or partially in the base. The width and depth of the base is less than or equal to the width and depth of the bottom inner surface dimensions of the housing such that the bottom inner surface area of the housing is entirely covered by one or more bases.

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Family ID:	1000008780895
Appl. No.:	17/838152
Filed:	June 10, 2022

Prior Publication Data

Document Identifier	Publication Date
US 20220338450 A1	Oct. 27, 2022

Related U.S. Application Data

continuation parent-doc US 16700075 20191202 US 11445709 child-doc US 17838152
continuation parent-doc US 16111002 20180823 US 10561121 20200218 child-doc US 16700075
continuation parent-doc US 16034991 20180713 US 11185058 20211130 child-doc US 16111002
continuation parent-doc US 15699734 20170908 ABANDONED child-doc US 16028895
continuation parent-doc US 15694035 20170901 ABANDONED child-doc US 15699734
continuation-in-part parent-doc US 16028895 20180706 US 11606938 child-doc US 16034991
continuation-in-part parent-doc US 15638082 20170629 ABANDONED child-doc US 15694035
us-provisional-application US 62456346 20170301

Publication Classification

Int. Cl.: A01K63/00 (20170101); B65D6/00 (20060101); B65D25/54 (20060101)

U.S. Cl.:

CPC A01K63/006 (20130101); B65D11/20 (20130101); B65D25/54 (20130101);

Field of Classification Search

CPC: A01K (63/006); B44C (5/06); A63H (33/42)

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Primary Examiner: Topolski; Magdalena

Background/Summary

CROSS-REFERENCE TO RELATED APPLICATIONS (1) This patent application is a Continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/700,075, filed on Dec. 2, 2019; which is a Continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/111,002, filed on Aug. 23, 2018, which is a Continuation-in-Part of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 16/028,895, filed on Jul. 6, 2018 which is a continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/699,734, filed Sep. 8, 2017, which is a Continuation of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/694,035, filed on Sep. 1, 2017, which is a Continuation-in-Part of U.S. patent application Ser. No. 15/638,082, filed on Jun. 29, 2017 and which claims benefit of U.S. Provisional Patent Application No. 62/465,346, filed on Mar. 1, 2017. (2) Applicant claims priority under 35 U.S.C. § 119 for each of the above listed applications, and incorporates each of these applications herein, in their entirety.

FIELD OF THE INVENTION

(1) The present invention relates generally to a decoration and more specifically to at least one ornament assembly that includes a base that substantially encompasses an entire surface area of a bottom wall of a housing, and into which base various decorative elements are irremovably disposed. Said base having a shape that can encompass an interior surface of a housing that is of a non-uniform shape, including, but not limited to a sloped, curved, semi-circular, global, and drum-shaped.

BACKGROUND OF THE INVENTION

(2) Decorative ornaments are commonly used in connection with aquariums, terrariums and other housings in addition to being standalone objects. For example, various decorations are regularly placed in aquariums to improve visual aesthetics and to provide fish and/or animals housed in the aquarium with an artificial environment akin to their natural habitat. Such decorations usually include a layer of material such as gravel and/or sand that can be one or more of a variety of colors, live and/or plastic plants, and other decorative objects such as coral, sunken ships, treasure chests, rocks, and/or signage.

(3) To create an aesthetically appealing effect in an aquarium, items must be purchased and then arranged in the aquarium. However, many individuals lack the creativity, know-how, time, and/or the patience to select and decorate an aquarium. Additionally, consumers do not always have access to decor which they desire.

(4) An aquarium, terrarium, or other housing is a habitat for fish, reptiles, or other creatures. It is a delicately balanced ecosystem created for fish, reptiles, or other creatures to thrive. Abrupt changes to such an ecosystem can alter the environment and endanger the lives of the fish, reptiles, or other creatures. These enclosures require regular cleaning to ensure the viability of life housed therein and the overall cleanliness thereof. This is often a very time-consuming process that requires the temporary removal of fish and/or other animals, movement, or removal of gravel and/or other decorative elements and at least in the case of an aquarium, the displacement and discarding of water from the aquarium (usually into a drain or toilet) that requires careful attention not to accidentally include gravel or other decorative elements so as not to discard such decorative elements with the displaced water, damaging the elements and/or possibly clogging the drain/toilet into which the water is being discarded.

(5) The soiled gravel and/or other decorative elements must be cleaned or replaced, and regardless of whether the decorative elements are cleaned or replaced, the movement and/or removal of gravel and/or decorative elements in order to clean an aquarium requires a significant commitment in both time and energy to move and/or remove the items, clean the items or replace them with a new

scheme and ensure the vitality of the aquatic life housed in the aquarium. Should one decide not to remove all decorative items and water from a housing when cleaning, commonly, material arranged on the base of the aquarium will be displaced and mixed with the water in the housing. If not handled properly, in the case of aquariums, the stirring of loose gravel when adding or moving decor, can alter the environment and create a toxic environment by causing high levels of ammonia gas and nitrates to be released into the aquarium water. The high gaseous levels, which emanate from waste from fish and/or animals in the aquarium and food particles not consumed that naturally break down in the material (e.g., gravel) placed on the base of the aquarium, can often damage the protective body-coating of fish and their delicate fins. The harsh nature of the gases can also lead to the onset of disease to the fish contained in the aquarium, and commonly leads to fish dying soon after being exposed to such gases (e.g., within about twenty-four hours). This is a frequent problem for consumers, especially those new to fishkeeping. The same applies to reptiles and small animals. Thus, there are many challenges and concerns with creating a desired decorative environment, cleaning an aquarium that includes a decorative environment and recreating a decorative environment after cleaning the aquarium.

SUMMARY OF THE INVENTION

(6) Accordingly, the present invention is directed to a decorative ornament assembly that substantially obviates one or more of the problems due to limitations and disadvantages of the related art.

(7) An object of the invention is to provide a decorative ornament assembly that fits within and covers the entire inner surface area of a container, such as a fish tank, all which may have different inner surface widths, lengths, depths and circumferences.

(8) Another object of the invention is to simplify the cleaning process of a housing, such as an aquarium, by allowing a user to quickly remove the decorative ornament assembly in one step rather than having to remove decorative elements in an open container, such as gravel, plants, and ornaments, individually.

(9) Yet another object of the invention is to simplify the decoration process of a holding container, such as an aquarium, by allowing users to insert a preconfigured decorative ornament assembly with all of the decorative elements affixed to it in advance rather than the user having to individually purchase and insert various decorative items, such as plants, gravel, and ornaments, into a holding container or removable substrate. The preconfigured decorative ornament, once installed in a container, looks as if the user selected and separately placed the substrate and various decorative ornaments while the user in fact only has to purchase it and put it in place.

(10) In an embodiment, the present invention is directed to an ornament assembly configured to be arranged within a housing that includes at least one sidewall. The ornament assembly comprises a base delimited at an outer periphery and a plurality of decorative elements that are at least one of irremovably disposed on and partially fixed within the base prior to receipt by the user. The base is configured to extend substantially about an interior space of the housing such that the base is contactable with the at least one sidewall of the housing.

(11) The base can extend across an entire surface area of a portion of the housing such that the entire portion of the housing is covered by the base. Alternatively, the portion of the housing can be entirely covered by two or more bases.

(12) The base can be comprised of at least one of gravel, sand, marbles, stones, plastic, paper, or any other type of suitable base material which are bound together to form a solid structure. The decorative elements can include plants, rocks, sunken ships, treasure chests, statues, signage, castles, and other decorative subject matter that appeals to consumers.

(13) The base can include at least one decorative ornament which is permanently affixed to the base and shaped so that it can be securely grasped by one hand of a user and used to lift the ornament assembly out of the housing using only one hand. This decorative ornament can be spaced towards the center of the base and away from the side walls and can have a footprint on the

base which encompasses the center of gravity along the plane of the base to make it easier for a user to keep the ornament assembly level when lifting it from the housing.

(14) In another embodiment, the present invention is directed to a system of decorating an open container that includes a base having a depth and delimited at an outer periphery and a plurality of decorative elements that are at least one of irremovably disposed on and partially fixed within the base and a housing that includes at least one sidewall. A width and a depth of the base is less than or equal to a width and a depth of an inner surface area of the housing, and the inner surface area of the housing is entirely covered by the base.

(15) The inner surface area of the housing can be entirely covered by two or more base portions that are contactable or adjacent to each other to form the decorative ornament assembly. The bases can be adjoined by abutting each other and can include magnets or engaging physical structures to align the bases relative to each other. The bases can also be connected together by a hinge or include a fastener or apparatus allowing the base portions to engage and form the decorative ornament assembly. When two or more base portions are used, the adjacent edges of the base portions and one or more decorative elements can be configured that when the bases are adjoined, the seam is obscured.

(16) In a further embodiment, the housing can have a double side wall with an opening along one edge into which a flat insert can be slid. The insert can be substantially the same size as the side wall and have decorative elements printed or formed thereon. A decorative insert can be configured to match the design of a particular ornament assembly or can contain other desired images or text. Different pairs of ornament assembly plus thematically associated inserts can be provided to allow a user to quickly and easily change the overall design. In a further configuration, the size of the housing and space for the insert can be configured to receive a conventional flat panel display or tablet computer on which a variety of static and/or moving media can be displayed. A frame can be provided to hold the insert Position the insert, make it easier to put in and take out

(17) A kit can be provided that includes one or more premade decorative ornament assemblies and a housing. In one arrangement, a single assembly and housing are sized so that the base extends substantially about an interior space of the housing such that the base is contactable with the at least one sidewall of the housing. The user can swap out one ornament assembly for another from the kit as desired. For a large housing, the kit may contain two or more decorative ornament assemblies which are configured to be used together to cover the inner surface area of the bottom of the housing. The kit can further comprise packaging to contain and protect the housing and the ornament assembly and that is configured to allow these components to be safely shipped together as a kit and distributed to commercial outlets. In one configuration, the ornament assembly is pre-installed within the housing and the packaging arranged to allow the housing and ornament assembly to be viewed while still within the packaging. In a particular configuration, the packaging comprises a base to receive the housing, a lid to cover the housing, and a strap or other component, such as tape, to secure the base lid in place while leaving substantially all of the side walls of the housing unobscured. The kit can include multiple different ornament assemblies so the user can select and change them as desired.

(18) The base can be made of at least one of gravel, sand, marbles, stones, rocks, plastic, paper, and a similar solidly formed substance, or a facsimiles thereof, or any other type of suitable base material which are bound together to form a solid structure. The decorative elements can be at least one of plants, rocks, sunken ships, treasure chests, statues, signage, castles, and other decorative subject matter that appeals to consumers.

Description

BRIEF DESCRIPTION OF THE DRAWINGS

- (1) FIG. 1A is a front perspective view of a first embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly of the present invention;
- (2) FIG. 1B is a front perspective view of the decorative ornament assembly of FIG. 1A arranged in a housing;
- (3) FIG. 1C is a diagram of part of a decorative ornament assembly showing a decorative element;
- (4) FIG. 1D is a bottom perspective view of a decorative ornament assembly;
- (5) FIG. 1E is directed to a front view of a base with a pair of ornaments thereon;
- (6) FIG. 2A is a front perspective view of a second embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly of the present invention;
- (7) FIG. 2B is a front perspective view of the decorative ornament assembly of FIG. 1A arranged in a housing;
- (8) FIG. 3 is a front perspective view of a third embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly of the present invention located in a housing;
- (9) FIG. 4A is a front perspective view of a fourth embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly of the present invention;
- (10) FIGS. 4B and 4C illustrate connection mechanisms for use in the fourth embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly;
- (11) FIGS. 5A and 5B are a front perspective views of a fifth and sixth embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly of the present invention;
- (12) FIG. 6 is a perspective view of a known aquarium shape;
- (13) FIG. 7 is a perspective view showing a decorative ornament assembly arranged in the aquarium of FIG. 6;
- (14) FIG. 8 is a perspective view of a seventh embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly arranged in a housing;
- (15) FIG. 9 is another known housing in which a decorative ornament assembly having a shape contoured to a portion of the inner surface area;
- (16) FIG. 10 is a perspective view of the housing of FIG. 9 showing an eighth embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly of the present invention arranged therein.
- (17) FIGS. 11A-11D and 12A-12D show various configurations of components the fourth embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly;
- (18) FIGS. 13A and 13B show a second embodiment of a housing for use with a decorative ornament assembly;
- (19) FIG. 14 shows a first embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly kit;
- (20) FIG. 15 shows another embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly kit.

DETAILED DESCRIPTION OF EMBODIMENTS OF THE INVENTION

- (21) Reference will now be made in detail to embodiments of the invention, examples of which are illustrated in the accompanying drawings. It is noted that the thicknesses of layers and regions in the drawings are exaggerated for clarity.
- (22) The decorative ornament assembly not only allows for an aesthetically pleasing appearance in a housing or on a surface, but also reduces the cost of purchasing several items to create such a decorative element, significantly reduces the time, expertise, imagination, creativity, and know-how required to create the desired decorative look. Otherwise, a user would need to select, acquire, and arrange the decorative elements on their own. The decorative ornament assembly also allows for easy removal from a container or from a surface to clean the container or surface and to clean or replace the decorative ornament assembly.
- (23) FIG. 1A is a front perspective view of a first embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly **100** of the present invention. The decorative ornament assembly **100** includes a base **110** that may have varying shapes, widths, depths, and heights depending on its intended use and stylization. The

base **110** can be comprised of gravel, sand, marbles, stones, plastic, paper, and/or a similar substance or another material which are bound together using various methods and materials that are well known in the art, such as epoxy or resin bonding, glue, or use of any other adhesive material to form a solid structure and into which decorative elements **120** are irremovably disposed. The ornament assembly is manufactured as a pre-configured item so that it can be purchased in a ready-to-use form with minimal or no additional configuration needed.

(24) The decorative elements **120** can include, for example, plants, statutes, signage, castles, sunken ships, treasure chests or other decorations are then irremovably disposed on or partially disposed in the base **110**. As such, because the decorative elements **120** stand freely in conjunction with the base **110**, they do not require repositioning or the aid of another structure to support the decorative elements **120** creating various environmental themes, such as an ocean, coral reefs, sunken cities, surfing, sailing, lighthouses on a cliff, forest, etc.

(25) During manufacture of the decorative ornament assembly **100**, the decorative elements **120** may be irremovably disposed on or partially in the base **110** by heating the base material, inserting the decorative elements **120** in or on the base material and then cooling the base **110** so the base material hardens and secures the decorative elements **120** therein or thereon. Alternatively, the decorative elements **120** may be inserted into, or attached to, the base **110** material, and then a resin, glue, or other adhesive material may be added to the base **110** so that it hardens into a single decorative ornament assembly. In a further configuration, the base and some decorative elements, such as coral shapes, buildings, or other solid elements, can be fabricated as an integral unit, such as through a resin molding or injection molding process. Other decorative elements may then be irremovably secured to the molded part separately from the molding process.

(26) As shown in in FIG. **1B**, the base **110** of the decorative ornament assembly **100** is configured and sized such that it encompasses substantially the entire surface area of a bottom wall within a housing **130**, such as an aquarium, terrarium, or other form of a vivarium, thereby providing a customized and professionally decorative appearance. As a result, the pre-formed base appears to fill the bottom of the housing all the way to the edges and, depending on the design and composition of the base, gives a visual appearance of a housing with a substrate of loose gravel, sand, marbles, stones, or other generally flowable granular materials poured into it. Moreover, the decorative ornament assembly **100** can be selectively removed and replaced with an alternative decorative ornament assembly which is also sized to fit on and cover the entire inner bottom surface area of the housing **130**.

(27) The base **110** of the ornament assembly **100** has a predetermined width, depth, and height wherein these dimensions allow it to fit along or within the bottom inner surface area of a housing, such as a glass tank or container of other material. The ornament assembly **100** may be sized to fit inside standard sized housings such as aquariums (i.e. 2.5, 5, or 10 gallon tanks) or custom shaped tanks and/or other housings or containers comprised of various materials (e.g., glass, composite, plastic, etc.).

(28) FIG. **1B** is a front perspective view of a first embodiment of the present invention located in a housing (e.g., a glass container, a glass tank, vase, or a container of another material). As shown in FIG. **1B**, the base **110** of the decorative ornament assembly **100** has a width and depth which conforms to the inner surface dimensions of the bottom of the housing **130**. If this housing **130** is an aquarium, the user can then add water and fish to the container to complete the aquarium setup.

(29) As the base **110** of the decorative ornament assembly **100** is affixed to the decorative elements **120**, a user can simply remove the decorative ornament assembly **100** in its entirety from a housing **130** by grabbing either the base **110** or decorative elements **120**. Removal of the entire decorative ornament assembly **100** from the housing in one step greatly simplifies the process of redecorating or cleaning a housing. For example, when the housing **130** is an aquarium, a user could easily clean the housing **130** by removing any contents thereof, such as fish/animals, removing the decorative ornament assembly **100**, and then draining the water contained in the housing **130**. The user would

then be able to easily clean the entire decorative ornament assembly **100** and the housing **130** and then re-insert the cleaned decorative ornament assembly **100** into the housing **130** that has been cleaned or insert an alternative decorative ornament assembly into the housing **130**.

(30) In a preferred embodiment, at least one decorative element **120'** that is affixed to the base is specifically configured and positioned so that a user can easily use that element to lift the ornament assembly **100** out of the housing **130** using a single hand. In a particular configuration, the decorative element is a rigid object that is large enough to be easily grabbed by a user's hand and shaped so that the user can get a secure grip on the decorative element **120'** even if the element is very slippery due to accumulated growth of algae, bacterial slime, or coatings, a likely condition when the removal is being done because the assembly needs cleaning.

(31) As shown in FIG. 1C, one arrangement of such as decorative element **120'** has at least two indented areas **121a** and **121b**, which are each at least one-quarter and preferably at least one-half inch deep and positioned so that one indent area can receive one or more fingertips and the other receive a thumb as the user grasps the decorative element **120'** with one hand. In a more specific configuration, the decorative element **120'** has first and second cross-sections **122a**, **122b** at points along an axis **123** extending up from the base. The second cross section **122b** is above and larger than the first cross section **122a** creating an area on the decorative element **120** where the fingers of a person grabbing the element can find a secure purchase. Preferably the first cross section **122a** is between Yz and 3 inches and the second cross section **122b** extends at least Yz inch further than the first cross section **122a** on generally opposite sides of the axis **123**.

(32) As will be appreciated, if the clearance between the base **110** of the ornament assembly **100** and the walls of the housing **130** is particularly tight and/or the base **110** particularly thick, tilting the ornament assembly as it is being inserted or removed may cause the edges of the base **110** to scrape and bind against the side walls of the housing **130**. If the ornament assembly **100** gets stuck, the user may push down or pull up on the ornament assembly **100** to try and free it, potentially causing damage to the base **110** or the housing **130**.

(33) According to a further aspect of the invention, and with reference to FIG. 1D, the decorative element **120'** intended to be used for lifting the ornament assembly **100** is located away from the outer periphery of the base **110** towards the center of the base **110**. The decorative element **120'** can be positioned so that when the ornament assembly **100** is being held by the designated decorative element **120'**, the assembly is relatively balanced so that it can easily be held in a flat position using one hand. In one configuration, the decorative element **120'** is positioned so that at least part of the profile **124** of the decorative element **120'** projected downward onto the base **110** is more than one-quarter of the width W of the base **110** from each side edge and more than one-quarter of the depth D of the base **110** from the front and back edges, and preferably more than one-third or more preferably two-fifths the width W and depth D. In another configuration, the decorative element **120'** is positioned so that its profile is over a center point C of the base **110**, such as the point where diagonal lines drawn between opposing corners of the base cross. In a further configuration, the decorative element **120'** is positioned so that its profile **124** is over a center of balance **125** of the ornament assembly. This configuration is particularly useful if the ornament assembly includes other decorative elements **120** that are heavy and arranged in an asymmetric manner.

(34) While the decorative element **120'** has been illustrated as a single element, such as a rock or a boat, in a particular configuration two or more decorative elements can be positioned near each other in the same area of the base and configured so that in combination they provide a gripping area that can be used to lift the ornament assembly out of the housing using a single hand in a manner similar to that for a single element. FIG. 1E, for example, illustrates a pair of decorative elements **120a**, **120b** configured as a branched tree or coral. Element **120a** has indented areas **121a** and element **120b** has indented areas **121b**. The indented areas are sized and positioned so that an indented area on one decorative element **120a**, **120b** can receive one or more fingertips and an indented area the other decorative element **120a**, **120b** receive a second fingertip, such as a thumb,

as the user grasps the pair of elements with one hand.

(35) On one embodiment, the base **110** is solid with no holes passing through it. Holes can act as a reservoir where bacteria, chemicals, and other residue harmful to fish may build up. Narrow holes can be difficult to clean and special cleaning tools can be required to do a thorough job. Also, when a user removes the ornament assembly **100** for cleaning, they may forget to clean out these holes, especially if the holes have filled with material and blend in to the rest of the base.

(36) In instances where the housing **100** is an aquarium, inserting or removing the ornament assembly **100** is made more difficult when the aquarium is filled with water because of water resistance and the close fit of the base **110** against the side walls of the housing **130**. In one configuration, the base **110** is sized so that there is sufficient gap between one or more edges of the base **110** and the adjacent walls of the housing **130** to permit enough water to flow past so that the ornament assembly **110** can be inserted or removed in only a seconds and yet where the gap is small enough so that it will not be apparent to a casual viewer when the base is installed. For example, the base **110** can be sized to provide a gap of less than one-quarter or more preferably less than $\frac{1}{8}$ inch between each edge of the base **110** and the adjacent wall of the housing **130**.

(37) In addition or alternatively, the edges of the base **110** may be formed with one or more inlets or notches around the periphery to form channels which allow for increased water flow around the base **110** as it is lifted or inserted. If the base **110** is made of relatively large granular materials, such as pebbles or marbles, the base **110** can be configured so that even if its edges contact one or more walls of the housing **110**, various natural looking gaps between the grains provide channels for water flow around the periphery of the base **110**. For example, FIG. 2B (discussed further below) shows a base **210** made of relatively large gravel pieces that are contacting the walls of the housing **230** but which define various channels **240** between the wall of the housing and the edge of the base **210** through which fluid can flow.

(38) In another embodiment, the base **110** of the decorative ornament assembly **100** can have one or more holes to allow for the insertion of a connecting a device for easier extraction of the decorative ornament assembly **100** from the housing **130**. The hole can include a helical ridge or other fastening ridges, allowing a connecting device to fasten into the base **110**. In addition, the hole can have a varying depth or extend through the base **110**. In instances where the decorative ornament assembly **100** is used in an aquarium, a through hole in the base **110**, instead of or in addition to notches along the edge of base **110**, allows water to pass through the base **110**, further minimizing resistance when removing the decorative ornament assembly **100** from a housing **130**. Preferably, such holes are large enough to be easily cleaned by a user so that they do not serve as a place where contaminants may remain even after cleaning of the ornament assembly **100**.

(39) The base **110** can be of varying sizes or shapes, including rectangular, square, circular, or any other particular shape in order to fully cover the bottom inner surface of a housing of any shape.

(40) FIG. 2A is a front perspective view of a second embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly **200**. The decorative ornament assembly **200** includes a base **210** comprised of gravel and other materials and decorative elements **220** that are fixed to the base **210** and/or each other (e.g., by an adhesive or formed together). By combining the base **210** with decorative elements **220**, the decorative ornament assembly **200** can act as a stand-alone decorative ornament or as a decorative centerpiece, such as those often found in restaurants, homes, bars, hotels, and other similar establishments. In such a case, a decorative ornament assembly **200** with various decorative elements **220** can be purchased and quickly and easily set into place without the need to purchase individual items or assemble the items to create a stand-alone decorative ornament or decorative centerpiece. The decorative ornament assembly **200** can be easily replaced, if and when needed, with an alternative decorative ornament assembly, for example, to reflect the different seasons of the year, holidays, occasions, sports, travel, or changes in personal taste in decor.

(41) FIG. 2B depicts the decorative ornament assembly **200** arranged within a housing **230**. The housing **230** has a square shaped bottom surface area, and the base **210** of the decorative ornament

assembly **200** includes a base **210** that has a width and depth that completely encompasses the inner surface area of the bottom of the housing **230**.

(42) Although a square open housing **230** is shown in FIG. 2B, the decorative ornament assembly **200** can be arranged in a variety of housings, such as aquariums, terrariums, vases, or any other container. Regardless of the housing in which the decorative ornament assembly **200** is arranged, the user would again gain the benefit of being able to place a complete decorative ornament assembly **200** that includes the base **210** and decorative elements **220** into a housing as opposed to having to purchasing those decorative elements individually and arranging those elements in the housing.

(43) FIG. 3 is a front perspective view of a third embodiment of a decorative ornament assembly **300** located within a housing **330**. The housing **330** is comprised of panels that can be comprised of, for example, glass, silicone glass, plastic, or another material. As shown, the housing **330** has a rectangular shaped bottom surface area, and the base **310** with the ornaments **320** of the decorative ornament assembly **300** is manufactured to substantially fit within the inner surface area of the housing **330**.

(44) Due to manufacturing and shipping limitations, along with concerns regarding weight of the decorative ornament assembly, the base of a decorative ornament assembly can only be so large. For example, a single decorative ornament assembly is not intended for use in large containers, such as a 50-gallon aquarium that has an inner width of 37 inches and a depth of 19 inches because the weight of the ornament assembly would make it difficult for a user to lift the assembly and/or place the assembly in such a container. If a single decorative ornament assembly that includes a base of about one inch in thickness and is made of polypropylene was used in conjunction with such a container, the base of the decorative ornament would have a volume of 703 cubic inches. Polypropylene has a weight of approximately 0.494 ounces per cubic inch. As such, in this example, the weight of the base alone, excluding additional weight provided by any decorative elements attached to the decorative ornament assembly, would be approximately 347 ounces, or nearly 22 pounds. If the base is made of a denser material, such as marbles or gravel, the weight would dramatically increase. Both the cumbersome size and weight of such a large decorative ornament assembly and corresponding base would obviate the benefits of the disclosed invention.

(45) In order to cover a large surface area without concern of having to lift a single heavy object and/or risk damaging a surface of a housing when arranging the object thereon, multiple decorative elements can be placed adjacent to each other, with a first part of the outer periphery of the base adjacent another base and a second part of the periphery adjacent the wall of the housing. As shown in an embodiment in FIG. 4A, a first decorative ornament assembly **400** and a second decorative ornament assembly **402** are arranged adjacent to each other in a housing **430**. The first decorative ornament assembly **400** includes a base **410** and at least one decorative element **420**. The base has a width that is less than width of the inner surface area of the housing **430**, but is still manufactured to fit within the inner surface area of the housing **430**. The second decorative ornament assembly **402**, which is placed adjacent the first ornament assembly **400**, includes a base **412** that has a width less than the width of the inner surface area of the housing **430** so as to also fit within the housing **430**. The width and length of bases **410** and **412** conforms to the inner surface dimensions of the bottom of the housing **430** and are manufactured in a manner that, when placed contiguously, the bases **410** and **412** fully cover the inner bottom surface of the housing **430**. Use of multiple decorative ornament assembly's to fully cover the inner surface area of the housing **430** will keep the weight of each decorative ornament assembly at a minimum. As with a single base, each ornament assembly section **400**, **402** can have a decorative element configured as discussed above to allow the section to be easily and securely grasped and lifted by one hand. In a particular multi-base configuration, and as addressed further below, a decorative element on one base can be positioned to interact with a corresponding decorative element on a second base when the two bases are placed adjacent each other along their first outer periphery portions. In one version of this

configuration, the interacting decorative element may be the one configured to be used to lift the respective base. It will be appreciated that in this embodiment, the decorative lifting element could be positioned away from the second outer periphery portion of the base but not necessarily away from the first outer periphery portion where the base abuts another base.

(46) In some cases, there may be a need to ensure that in a decorative ornament assembly that comprises multiple bases, the bases remain adjacent to each other when arranged in a container. In such a case, the pieces can be fastened to each other by any known means including the use of adhesives, locking mechanisms, magnets, etc. or combined by a hinge system (e.g., living hinge, mechanical hinge system). FIG. 4B shows a portion of base **404** with parts **404a** and **404b** connected to each other by a mechanical hinge **440**. FIG. 4C shows a portion of base **405** with parts **405a** and **405b** with fastening element **450a**, **450b** and **452a**, **452b** used to join the two parts together and help hold them in place relative to each other. The fastening elements **450a**, **b** and **452a**, **b** can be magnets or a combination of magnets and a ferrous metal. Alternatively they can be mating elements such as male pins bulges to interface with opposing holes or detents.

(47) In particular configurations using two or more ornamental assemblies to cover the bottom of a housing, the ornamental assemblies are configured that when the bases are adjoined, the seam between the two parts is obscured or blended into the base or decorative elements on it. Various configurations are possible. In addition, although the adjacent base edges can be straight, the adjacent edges can also have undulating or irregular contours that mate against each other so that the seam is not a straight line and so may be less noticeable for this reason.

(48) FIG. 11A shows a portion of ornament assemblies **1100a** with base **1102a** and decorative element **1104a** and a portion of ornament assembly **1100b** with base **1102b** and decorative element **1104b**. As shown in FIG. 12A, when the bases **1102a** and **1102b** are brought together, decorative elements **1104a** and **1104b** combine to give the appearance of a single larger decorative element **1204**. In this configuration, the mating faces **1105a**, **1105** of the decorative elements **1104a** and **1104b** have substantially the same shape. If the mating faces **1104a** and **1104b** are flat, each base element **1102a**, **1102b** could also be used individually in an appropriately sized housing and mating face **1004a**, **1004b** would rest flush against a wall of the housing.

(49) FIG. 11B shows a portion of ornament assemblies **1110a** with base **1112a** and decorative element **1114** and a portion of ornament assembly **1110b** with base **1112b**. Decorative element **1114** has a portion **1116a** that extends past the edge of the base **1112a**. As shown in FIG. 12B, when the bases **1112a** and **1112b** are brought together, decorative elements **1114** rests over region **1116b** of base **1112b**, obscuring the seam in that area.

(50) FIG. 11C shows a portion of ornament assemblies **1120a** with base **1122a** and decorative element **1124a** and a portion of ornament assembly **1120b** with base **1122b** and decorative element **1124b**. With reference to FIG. 12C, the decorative elements **1124a**, **124b** are configured to engage with each other to give the appearance of a single larger decorative element **1224** when the bases **1122a** and **1122b** are brought together. In this example, elements **11224a** and **1124b** interact to give the appearance of a house-like structure.

(51) As will be appreciated, some or all of the area where adjacent ornament assemblies intersect may lack a decorative element. In such a case, the adjoining edges of the base can be configured to overlap and the overlapping parts designed to visually blend into each other. FIG. 11D shows pair of a base portion **1130a** and part of base portion **1130b**. In this example the bases **1130a** and **1130b** are formed of gravel. Base **1130a** has an overhanging portion **1136a** which will fit over cheek **1136b** on base **1130b**. As shown in FIG. 12D, the gravel portions on the overlapping part is at least somewhat irregular and the two parts designed so that when the bases **1130a** and **1130b** are brought together, the area of intersection visually appears as a generally continuous surface.

(52) As will be appreciated, in the configurations of FIGS. 11A-D and 12A-D, additional decorative elements (not shown) can be provided on each base portion as may be desired or appropriate, including a decorative element **120'** configured to allow a user to grab and remove the

ornamental assembly section using a single hand as may be needed. In addition, while the seam where the base parts intersect is illustrated as running from front to back of the container, the base portions can be configured so that the seam runs from side to side or even at an angle, such as diagonally between opposing corners. These positions may make the intersection area even harder to see.

(53) In an embodiment, the decorations, including, but not limited to, ornaments and plants, can be releasably connected to the base so that the base and decorations can be shipped and/or packaged separately and various decorations can be replaced/interchanged to vary the decor as desired. This could possibly aid in packaging of the decorations in a further attempt to avoid damage to the decorations and reduce shipping fees.

(54) For example, the base can include openings that can receive a connector from a plant (e.g., male-female connecting system), the base can include projections that extend into a receptor attached to the end of a plant, the base can include magnets that interact with decorations having magnets of an opposite polarity, dowels or the like can be used to connect decorations and the base or any other connection method that is known or may become known can be used to releasably attach decorations to the base.

(55) The aforementioned advantages of the current invention also apply as will be described in further detail below, if the decorative ornament assembly of the present invention is used in connection with other containers, such as terrariums, globes, drums, or as a stand-alone decorative ornament, as opposed to with aquariums.

(56) As shown in embodiments in FIG. 5A and FIG. 5B, a decorative ornament assembly, here indicated by reference numerals **500A** and **500B**, respectively, can include a base **502A**, **502B**, respectively, that has a depth that can be arranged in a housing that includes a contoured and/or curved sidewall. As such, the base **502A**, **502B** can substantially encompass an inner surface area of the housing without leaving a gap between the base **502A**, **502B** and the bottom portion of the housing or requiring gravel, sand, or the like to be placed beneath the base **502A**, **502B** as a filler, defeating the purpose of the one-piece ornament assembly.

(57) The decorative ornament assemblies of the present invention may have varying shapes, widths, depths, and heights depending on their intended use and stylization. For example, a base **704** of a decorative ornament assembly **700** as can be seen in FIG. 7 that is designed for use with a known housing **600** (see FIG. 6) can include sloping contoured sidewalls **706** such that the base **704** tapers toward a bottom portion of the housing **700**. If traditional decorative elements were used in place of the decorative element **702** shown in FIG. 7, cleaning a housing such as the one shown in FIGS. 6 and 7 can be very time consuming and require extensive rearrangement and/or replacement of decorative elements

(58) FIG. 8 illustrates a perspective view of another known housing **800** in which a decorative ornament assembly **802** is arranged. As can be seen, the decorative ornament assembly **802** includes a base **804** with sloping sidewalls **806** that substantially contour to an interior space of the housing **800**.

(59) FIG. 9 illustrates another known housing **900** that includes a first semi-circular or dome shaped portion **902** that has a first rim **908** and a second semi-circular or dome shaped portion **904** that has a second rim **906** which is contactable with and seals within or around the first rim **904** of the first semi-circular or dome shaped portion **902**. Although the container **900** is shown to rest on a base, the container **900** can be hung and/or not contain a base as well.

(60) FIG. 10 depicts a decorative ornament assembly **1000** that is arranged in the housing **900** of FIG. 9. As shown, in order to substantially account for the interior space of the housing **900**, the decorative ornament assembly **1000** has a base **1002** with sloping sidewalls **1004** and a substantially linear bottom wall **1006**.

(61) FIG. 13A shows a further configuration of a housing **1300**. The housing **1300** is generally box shaped with four sides and a base and can be made of a transparent material. One side **1310** of the

housing **1300** is formed with a double wall having a first wall **1312a** and second wall **1312b** spaced apart and parallel to the first wall **1312a**. The top area between the walls **1312a** and **1312b** is open to define a narrow rectangular slot **1314** providing access to interior region **1316**. Preferably, walls **1312a** and **1312b** are separated by a gap of between about 1/16 of an inch to two inches and more preferably between about one-quarter to one inch.

(62) An insert **1320**, substantially the same dimensions as side **1310** or smaller can be slid into the interior region. The insert **1320** can be flat and made of paper, plastic, metal, or other sheet material. The insert **1320** functions as a backdrop to display in the housing **1300** and can have decorative indicia printed or formed thereon. The double wall **1320** makes easy for a user to remove and replace one insert with another in order to quickly and easily change the look of the display in the housing **1300**. A cover (not shown), such as an injection molded cap, can be provided to close the slot **1314** and keep water and other materials from getting in and possibly damaging the insert.

(63) The insert **1320** can have a design that matches the design of a particular ornament assembly. Different sets of ornament assembly plus a thematically associated insert can be provided to allow a user to quickly and easily change the overall design within the housing. For example, a set of four pairs of an ornamental assembly plus insert can be provided, each having a theme for a given season (spring, summer, fall, winter). Other insert designs can be provided as well that may be independent of the design of any specific ornament assembly. For example, the insert can be a photograph of a person or couple to serve as a memento or commemorate an event. The insert can include an image of a ship, house, hotel, landscape, or anything else to look upon. In one configuration, the housing is sized so that the interior region **1316** is slightly larger than a standard printed photograph, such as 4×6, 5×7, or 8×10, 10×13, etc. For example, the width can exceed the photo size by ¼ inch to one inch.

(64) In a further configuration, the insert can be a conventional flat panel display, digital picture frame, or tablet computer **1350** on which a variety of static and/or moving media can be displayed. The size of the housing and space for the insert can be configured to accept devices of this type. FIG. **13B** shows a cross-section of a housing, such as housing **1300** of FIG. **13A**, between the double walls **1312a**, **1312b**. A tablet display **1350** is inserted through the slot **1314** and into the interior region **1316**. To make it easier for a user to insert and remove the tablet display **1350**, a U-shape frame **1360** can be provided. The frame **1360** is sized to fit within the interior region **1316** of the housing and to receive the tablet display **1350**. In use, the tablet display **1350** is placed into the frame **1360** and the combined frame assembly lowered into the interior region **1316**. Frame extensions **1362** can be provided which can hook onto the edge of housing to make it easier for a user to grab the frame. To remove the display, the frame is simply lifted up. The width of the sides and base of the frame can be configured to receive a specifically sized tablet computer and to position it within the housing. Different sized frames can be provided to adapt differently sized tablet computers to a given housing size.

(65) A similar frame can be used to hold flexible non-rigid inserts, such as printed paper or photographs, to make it easier to insert and remove them and to frame the inserts within the housing if the housing size is larger than the insert. For example, a U-shaped frame can be sized to receive a 5×7 photograph (e.g. in a shallow slot formed along the inside of the frame) and position it centered within the interior region **1316** of a 6×8 inch container.

(66) The frame can be a stand-alone component. Alternatively, it can be connectable to a cover or cap provided to close the slot **1314**. For example, upper ends of the frame can have hooks that connect to rings formed on the bottom of the cap.

(67) In a further embodiment, and with reference to FIG. **14**, a kit **1400** is provided that comprises at least one decorative ornament assembly **1402** (having a base **1410** to which there is at least one decorative element **1420** irremovably disposed). The kit **1400** further includes at least one housing **1430**. The decorative element **1402** and housing **1430** are sized so that when the ornament

assembly **1402** is placed in the housing **1430** the base **1410** covers substantially all of the bottom of the housing **1430** as described above.

(68) In one configuration, the kit is provided to a user with the ornament assembly **1402** pre-installed within the housing **1430** and the combined elements contained within a carrier or box. In a preferred embodiment, the carrier is configured to allow at least one side of the ornament assembly and preferably a majority of the housing with the ornament assembly therein to be seen while still securing the parts of the kit. In the configuration of FIG. **12**, the carrier comprises a base **1450** to receive the bottom of the housing **1430**, a lid **1460** to cover the housing, and a strap **1470** or other component, such as tape, to secure the base **1450** and lid **1460** in place. One or more decorative inserts for a double-walled housing can also be provided as appropriate. One or more spacers **1470** can be included that span the space between an underside of the lid **1460** and a top surface of the base **1410** in order to secure the decorative assembly **1402** in place within the housing **1430**.

Spacers **1470** can be made of cardboard, plastic, or other generally rigid material.

(69) The kit can include multiple different ornament assemblies. The user can then easily remove one from the housing and replace it with another.

(70) In one further configuration, and with reference to FIG. **15**, a kit **1500** can include a housing **1430** and two ornament or more ornament assemblies, such as ornament assemblies **1502a** and **1502b**. The plural ornament assemblies can be inserted into the housing **1430** and kept apart from each other with one or more spacers **1570**. In one arrangement, one ornamental assembly **1502a** is placed in the bottom of the housing **1430**. A second ornamental assembly **1502b** is positioned in the housing at the top but oriented upside-down. Spacers **1570** keep the two ornamental assemblies **1502a**, **1502b** separate from each other. Using a carrier having base **1450** and lid **1460** as discussed with respect to FIG. **14** secures the two ornamental assemblies in place and allows them both to be viewed while the kit is within the carrier.

(71) The base of all embodiments can be comprised of gravel, sand, marbles, stones, plastic, paper, and/or a similar substance or another material which are bound together using various methods and materials that are well known in the art, such as epoxy or resin bonding, glue, or use of any other adhesive material to form a solid structure and into which decorative elements are irremovably disposed. The decorative elements for all embodiments can include, for example, plants, statutes, signage, castles, sunken ships, treasure chests or other decorations are then irremovably disposed on or partially disposed in the base. As such, because the decorative elements stand freely in conjunction with the base, they do not require repositioning or the aid of another structure to support the decorative elements creating various environmental themes, such as an ocean, coral reefs, sunken cities, surfing, sailing, lighthouses on a cliff, forest, etc.

(72) Although embodiments of decorative ornament assemblies are shown herein to include substantially linear bases, bases with sloping or conical sidewall, etc., the decorative ornament assemblies of the present invention can include a base having any configuration, including bases with varying depths and shapes to be arranged in a variety of housings, such as aquariums, terrariums, vases, or any other container.

(73) Although the description above and figures contains much specificity, the details provided should not be construed as limiting the scope of the embodiments, but merely as describing some of the features of the embodiments. The description and figures should not to be taken as restrictive and are understood as broad and general teachings in accordance with the present invention. While the embodiments have been described using specific terms, such description is for illustrative purposes only, and it is to be understood that modifications and variations to such embodiments, including, but not limited to, the substitutions of equivalent features and terminology may be readily apparent to those of skill in the art based upon this disclosure without departing from the spirit and scope of the invention.

Claims

1. A decorative system for an aquarium comprising: an aquarium housing which includes a bottom for defining an inner surface area and at least one sidewall; at least two decorative ornament assemblies, each decorative ornament assembly having a respective visual design creating a corresponding respective environmental theme, the at least one of the decorative ornament assemblies comprising a first decorative ornament assembly having a first visual design with a corresponding first environmental theme; each respective decorative ornament assembly comprising a base and one or more decorative elements, the base being delimited at an outer periphery, the base forming a solid structure to which said one or more decorative elements are permanently affixed in position thereon and upwardly depend therefrom without the aid of a separate supporting structure, at least one of said decorative elements being located away from said outer periphery of said base with the base having the same size and shape as that of the bottom inner surface area of the aquarium housing; wherein each respective decorative ornament assembly is selectively and independently receivable within said aquarium housing such that said bottom inner surface area of said aquarium housing is entirely covered by the base of said respective ornament assembly with the outer periphery of the respective ornament assembly base abutting said at least one sidewall of the aquarium housing when a selected ornament assembly is seated within said aquarium housing; wherein each respective decorative ornament assembly is structurally designed to be selectively removable from said aquarium housing by means of grabbing said at least one of said decorative elements located away from said base outer periphery in order to lift out said respective ornament assembly from said aquarium housing; a carrier having the aquarium housing and ornament assembly removably contained therein; wherein the aquarium housing is transparent, the carrier being configured to allow a majority of the assembly within the aquarium housing to be seen without opening the carrier; the carrier comprising a bottom part for receiving the bottom of the aquarium housing, a top part for covering a top of the aquarium housing, and at least one strap to secure the bottom part and top part of the carrier to the aquarium housing; a spacer; the at least two decorative ornament assemblies packaged within the carrier such that one of the at least two decorative ornament assemblies are positioned within the carrier, the bottom of the aquarium housing securely held within the bottom part of the carrier, the at least two decorative ornament assemblies packaged within the carrier such that one of the at least two preconfigured decorative ornament assemblies is positioned within the aquarium housing and securely held against the bottom of the aquarium housing, the other one of the at least two preconfigured decorative ornament assemblies is positioned and securely held in the top part of the carrier; wherein the spacer is positioned between the at least two ornament assemblies holding them within respective top and bottom parts of the carrier.
2. The system of claim 1, wherein for each respective ornament assembly the base is made of at least one of gravel, sand, marbles, stones, rocks, paper, and plastic, which are bound together to form a solid structure.
3. The system of claim 1, wherein for each respective ornament assembly the outer periphery of the base is contoured and includes at least one inclined surface.
4. The system of claim 1, wherein at least one of the decorative ornament assemblies has a one-piece construction.
5. The system of claim 1, the at least two decorative ornament assemblies further comprising a second decorative ornament assembly having a second visual design; said second ornament assembly creating a second environmental theme and including a base and one or more decorative elements, the base having an outer periphery, the base of the second ornament assembly forming a solid structure to which said one or more decorative elements are permanently affixed in position thereon and upwardly extend therefrom without the aid of a separate supporting structure, at least

one of said decorative elements being located away from said outer periphery of said base, the second ornament assembly base having the same size and shape as that of the bottom inner surface area of the aquarium housing.

6. The system of claim 1, wherein each decorative element is one of a plant, a rock, a ship, a treasure chest, a statue, a sign, and a castle.
